Reviewer 3 v.1

Comments to the Author

This is a good paper to look at what we can find from meta-analysis now. I have one major comment about a study included in the analysis and a few other minor notes.

The inclusion of the study by Bo that used EBUS seems to problematize the results in a similar manner to how the Jiang meta-analysis was affected by including ENB. By using the study by Bo you're including biopsies performed with ultrasound image guidance in with the "control" NVBNA, which in the other studies has no comparable guidance. Even if all I knew about the Bo study was that they compared EBUS-GS with EBUS-GS & VBN, I would expect much less of a difference in diagnostic yield than you'd see with NVBNA compared to VBNA. That's how the data plays out in your analysis. The study by Bo is by far the most weighted in your analysis of overall diagnostic yield and has the 2nd worst M-H of all the studies. If it was omitted it appears looking at your Forest plot that you would likely find that VBNA does improve overall diagnostic yield. I think it makes sense to not include it because the data from it that you're including in the NVBNA group has a different form of image guidance (EBUS) in it as opposed to all the rest of the data. At a minimum I think you should show how things would look if you didn't lump EBUS in with a subset of your data. The addition of EBUS should have some impact on most of the outcomes you're looking at.

As for more minor notes:

On page 9 line 12 (last sentence before the "Secondary Outcomes" you say "there was no heterogeneity among studies" and I assume you meant "no significant heterogeneity"

In Figure 3, I know it is just following standard methods for how to show a Forest plot, but when I look at it and read under the x-axis "Favours NVBNA" and "Favours VBNA" and see the data on the side that says "Favours NVBNA" it initially makes me think that NVBNA does better on examination time.